

FOUR FLIGHTS

It was one of those days where the heat made everyone stupid.

No air con. Confined spaces. The kind of temperature that turns minor irritations into major incidents. You could feel it in the wing — that particular tension where everyone's a little shorter, a little quicker to snap.

Yard time came and I didn't take it.

I'd finished my jobs for the day — mopping floors, emptying bins, the wing cleaner shit that bought me extra unlock time and additional milk portions. My celly was out in the yard. Most of the others too. I stayed inside for a couple of games of pool while the wing was quiet.

Small freedoms. They matter when every hour feels the same.

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Yard time ended. The screws brought everyone back in.

I was lining up my shot when Jay walked through.

He walked straight to the pool table and used it as a stretching post. Foot up on the felt. Doing what Jay did — which was whatever the fuck he felt like.

In the process, he knocked a couple of balls out of position. One of them had been set for my shot.

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I'd been in plenty of bare-knuckle fights by then.

Varying degrees. Much bigger men than Jay. The worst I'd ever come off was a split lip or eyebrow. Never feared any of it.

So I reacted.

"Seriously? Ya have to fucken do that there?"

Jay stopped. Looked up from his stretched pose.

The change was instant. Facial expression. Body language. From the clown who was intentionally inconveniencing someone because he could — to stone cold anger.

I'd seen that look before. It didn't scare me.

"Who the fuck you talking to?"

He grabbed one of the snooker balls. Dropped his leg off the table. Took a stance that came with intimidation.

Still didn't faze me.

"I'm talking to you. Ya can see we're in the middle of a game. Ya come in, stretch on the table when I'm about to take a shot, move the balls around — why the fuck don't you use one of the benches?"

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That's when the rage boiled over.

You could see it in his face. Steam rising off him. He advanced towards me gripping the snooker ball in his hand — picture a silverback gorilla, just five foot tall.

That was Jay.

"Watch your fucken mouth, white boy, before I cave your fucken head in."

He launched the ball at the concrete floor.

The sound was like a gunshot. The whole wing turned. Every eye in the place suddenly on us.

The ball bounced a couple of times before I caught it.

I laughed. Continued on with the game.

Nothing more came of that situation.

Not that day, anyway.

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The next morning, the nurses collected me.

I'd been waiting to get my ears drained — gone basically deaf in my left ear from solid wax buildup due to a narrow ear canal. Finally getting it sorted.

The infirmary was still locked doors everywhere, but a little less prison. A bit more doctor's office vibe.

I was sitting in the waiting area when I saw him in my peripheral.

Joel.

Near enough seven foot tall. Arms the size of most people's quads. Long hair always tied back in a neat short ponytail. Clean-shaven. Old-school iron cross lad — not patched, but closely affiliated with the Road Knights.

A screw was walking him up the stairs.

They got to the reinforced glass door. The screw unlocked it. Then just kept walking down the hallway. Out of sight.

Joel sat down next to me.

That's the pull he had. He knew where I was. He knew we could speak in private. And he'd been knowingly escorted through the prison to do exactly that.

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We had a quick yarn.

I asked how his ma was. He asked how I was settling in.

Then the reason he was there.

"So, bruva — what's this shit with Jay you got going on?"

Nothing really, I told him. The fuckwit came in from yard, stretched out over the pool table, fucked our game up. I told him to get the fuck on and he threw his toys out of the cot.

"Hahaha. Good man." He paused. "But he's pissed, bruva. He's come to me for permission to take care of things on the way to mess hall for dinner."

Permission.

That's how it worked. Prison politics. Hierarchy. Nothing major happens without the nod from someone who matters.

"The crazy fuck wants to shank ya and throw ya off the stairs."

Four flights. That's what separated the wing from the mess hall.

Who the fuck does that cunt think he is, I said. He'd better hope he's fucken quick. You know I'm not gonna let that happen.

"Well, it's not gonna happen. I didn't give him the green light — which just fucked him off even more."

Joel looked at me.

"But it's gonna require a public apology for disrespecting him."

Get fucked. An apology? I'm not—

"And you're gonna give him that apology. Then steer clear of him before shit gets out of hand and we got a war on our hands."

I stopped.

All good, bruva. If that's what you want, then you know I'm not gonna argue.

"Good man." He leaned in. "Drop back to the end of the line on the way to mess hall tonight. Don't get hot-headed with this cunt. Give him the apology — but don't turn your back to him, and don't stop walking up the stairs. He's a ticking time bomb and may not even follow orders. Be ready."

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From around the corner, the screw appeared.

Said nothing as he passed. Unlocked the door.

Joel stood. Turned to me.

"Heil, brother."

Then he walked out, and off they went.

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I was now in a scenario where my life literally depended on one of two things.

Either a hot-headed gang president followed prison rules and accepted the decision handed down on his own request.

Or I'd need to react fast enough to stop a madman from shanking me and throwing me down four flights of stairs.

Not an ideal place to be.

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That night, Ivian kept close as we went to dinner.

My connection to Joel was the only reason I was still walking.

The walk to mess hall. Four flights of stairs. Every step knowing there was a ticking time bomb somewhere behind me who'd wanted to kill me that morning.

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Jay came up the stairs.

Shouldered into me.

"You fucken lucky cunt."

I kept walking. Didn't stop. Didn't turn my back.

Yeah, look, Jay — I apologise for any disrespect. It won't happen again.

"Next time I don't give a fuck. I'll cave your fucken head in right there in the wing."

He stormed up the stairs ahead of me. Pushing his way through the others.

That was it.

An apology I didn't mean. For a fucking pool game. To a man who'd wanted me dead that morning.

I stayed out of Jay's way after that. Not because I was scared of him.

Because I'd learned what my pride was worth in there.

Exactly one walk up four flights of stairs.

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The parole board happened a few weeks later.

My brother had wagged school to be there. He was fifteen — not allowed into the prison due to not being eighteen. But somehow he'd managed to get in with Stacey as a support person.

First time I'd seen him in three months. Since the courtroom, when I'd mouthed *catch ya on the flipside* and given him that stupid salute.

I had no idea he was going to be there. That was a real buzz.

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The board meetings were held in the admin block.

Very corporate feel. Big wooden doors. Long solid wood tables. Marble floors. The kind of room designed to make you feel small.

We'd gone through the process beforehand — Department of Corrections and New Zealand Police had visited Stacey's mum's house to assess the suitability for home detention. Who else would be in the home. Whether the request was being made with full support of the lease holder.

All that sort of shit.

The meeting itself was split into two parts.

A bland, almost corridor-type waiting room with standard steel-framed desk chairs. Behind the big doors was the board.

Six of them, I think. Three women, three men. All sitting on one side of the table's length.

Single chair on the other side.

Support people weren't allowed in.

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They asked for supporting documents. Letters from family. My behaviour record from the prison. Whether I was affiliated with any gangs.

Then why I believed I should be granted home detention for the remainder of my sentence.

I made my case.

Then they sent me back out to the waiting area while they made their decision.

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I'd barely walked out of the room.

The door was still slowly closing to full seal when I was called back in.

That fast.

They'd already decided before I'd finished speaking.

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An older lady read out the decision. Early fifties. The chair of the board.

She wasted no time.

The application was denied due to my extensive history of breaching bail conditions. Every single bail condition ever imposed on me between the ages of thirteen and nineteen — some of which had been breached multiple times. I had never completed any community work-based sentencing. Never paid any reparation.

She said it with a tight smile. The kind that says: *what did you expect?*

I wouldn't be eligible to reapply for a further six months.

Which basically meant I was doing the full stretch.

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I walked back out to the corridor.

Stacey was gutted. My brother just looked at me.

I wasn't fazed by it.
It is what it is.

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The walk back to the wing was short. Escorted. Nothing to say.
Home detention wasn't coming. Which meant the visits were all I had.

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Stacey came every Sunday.

When I was sentenced, a new visiting hall was only just being constructed — modern, no direct contact between inmate and visitor, the kind of thing you see in movies. Because of that, most of my visits were held in the gymnasium instead.

Old-style bench seats. The kind you'd see at school assemblies.

All inmates in bright orange overalls that went on over your prison blues and zipped up from the back. A screw would security-tag the zipper, your wrist cuffs, and ankle cuffs.

But you got to sit with your visitor.

She'd walk ninety minutes each way to sit with me for an hour. Rain, hail, didn't matter. She'd moved in with her mum so she was in the same city as the prison, but it was still a solid walk.

Banked enough money each week for my smokes and a pack of choc chip cookies.

Twice a week, a letter would arrive — always a week behind due to processing. The first half was updates. The second half was filthy. Which was great.

I never told her any of the heavy stuff. Didn't want her worrying for no reason.

She was betting on me before there was anything to bet on.
Same board. Same day. Different histories.

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